

NOTED COLORED OFFICER IS KILLED BY HIS WIFE

Nat Blanks, the colored deputy sheriff at Clearview, was shot through the heart and instantly killed by his wife in their home in that colored town Friday night at 12:30 o'clock, as the culmination of trouble that seems to have arisen between them a few days previously.

On Wednesday Blanks had accosted Joe Reynolds, a colored resident of Clearview, about statements he should have made about Blanks's wife, but Reynolds denied any connection with the rumors and Blanks went home. Blanks's wife questioned Nat as to what Reynolds had told him, and became convinced that the man had told her husband something detrimental to her character, got a six-shooter and went to Oliver's store where Reynolds works, and fired three shots at him, one ball passing through his right hand. Had the man not fled for his life and finally hid behind a door from whence he jumped out and disarmed the woman as he passed it is said that he would almost certainly have been killed.

A few hours after this trouble Blanks himself accosted Dock Alford, a druggist of Clearview on the streets, and charged him with too close an intimacy with his wife, and drew his gun on Alford. The druggist, who was accompanied by his sister, denied Blanks's charges, grabbed his sister and held her between him and Blanks, while the frightened woman begged the angry negro not to shoot. Blanks finally desisted. Sheriff Berry Jones learned something of these matters and went to Clearview Thursday and talked with the Blanks. The Blanks woman said that she believed her husband was losing his mind and that she wanted him to be examined by some brain specialist. The sheriff says Blanks talked as usual and seemed to be perfectly rational. The sheriff told them he would let their troubles go over until Monday when he would come back and they would decide what steps to take in the Reynolds and Alford affairs.

Friday night about 12:30 o'clock, according to the Blanks woman's account of the end, Blanks and she were talking in their bedroom when he threw his left arm around her and drew her to him, at the same time drawing and cocking his six-shooter and placed the muzzle against her breast. She asked him what he was going to do, and if he intended to kill her, and begged him not to shoot, when he finally smiled, laid the gun down and turning started to lay down on the bed. Just as he was in the act of lying down, she says she does not think he had got clear down, she snatched up the gun and fired one shot and knew she hit him, but did not know just where. She then ran from the room, and gave the alarm. When the officers reached the house they found Blanks's body lying on the bed on his back, his left hand on his breast, his right at his side like he had been killed in his sleep. The bullet passed through his heart.

N. H. Starks, the colored justice of the peace at Clearview, called a jury and an inquest was held over the body and some testimony taken. The woman admitted the shooting and gave as her reason for killing her husband that she was afraid he intended to kill her. The jury returned a verdict that the deceased came to his death from a gun shot wound inflicted by his wife, Mrs. M. J. Blanks, and she was brought to the county jail to await a preliminary hearing.

Monday morning a preliminary was waived and a habeas corpus proceeding instituted in the superior court to have the woman admitted to bail and a hearing was had before Judge John L. Norman Tuesday morning.

The evidence given by the accused was about as stated above, but she said that for the past four years Blanks had kept her in a constant state of terror by his threats; that she was, at the time she shot him, afraid to run and was afraid to stay in the room with him. J. E. Thompson and three other colored men testified that Blanks had made threats against his wife's life in their presence, but that they had not told the woman of the threats.

Judge Norman held that bail was admissible and fixed the bond at \$7,500 which was made by Thompson and several other Clearview colored men.

The county attorney has filed an information against the Blank woman for shooting with intent to kill Reynolds, and a hearing is fixed for Monday before Judge W. J. Lawrence.

Nat Blanks was one of the best known colored officers in Okfuskee county. He was fearless in the face of danger, quiet, and trustworthy, and was highly regarded by the sheriffs who have for several years used him as a deputy in the big colored community around Clearview. Several years ago trouble was caused at a big colored camp meeting in Clearview by a crowd of rowdies who undertook to break up the meeting. Blanks was entrusted with the task of preserving order and the first night the disturbers and Blanks came to an open rupture resulting in a gun fight. When the fight was over two of the rough-necks were dead, but Blanks was uninjured. One of the dead men proved to be a cousin of Ches Chambers of Boley, who when he learned of the affair, took the train for Clearview and began a hunt for "the man who killed my cousin." After inquiring from several crowds of colored men he came up to one crowd with which Blanks was standing talking and when Chambers